

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD ☐UNUSUAL RECORD ☒

Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.

Species: Le Conte's Sparrow | Ammodramus leconteii
(Vernacular Name) December 20, 1990 1 adult (Scientific Name)Date: December 2, 1990; Arctic front moving in, +20°F, wind chills -15°FNumber of birds seen: 4 Sex: Unknown Plumage: First-yearLocality: John Martin Reservoir marsh (see below) Elevation: 3850' ±Nearest town: Fort Lyon County: BentTime observed: 10:30 AMDuration of observation (e.g. 1 sec., 5 min., etc.): 5 minutes

Other observers who saw the bird with you (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

None
 bird seen by X

Other observers who saw the bird independently (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

On December 3, 1990 Mark Janos, Bob Dickson, and Van Truan of Pueblo
 On December 30, 1990 Joe Roller and Joey Kellner saw 3 birds

Light conditions (position of bird to light and shade, direction and strength of light):
 Sunny morning. No wind. Temp. 35°. At first I was looking toward the sun but I moved off to the side

Optical equipment used (e.g. power, types): 8X binocularsDistance, and how measured: ~~30~~ 30-50 feet est.If photographed, type of equipment and film: NOWho else photographed the bird? —

Describe the bird's behavior (e.g. flying, feeding, or habits used in identifying):

The first bird was chipping faintly. As I moved closer it flew from cover in long, matted marsh grass to a 2' cottonwood sapling and sat + sat + sat. At first only the back was toward me, but I could get glimpses of the face and top of head as it turned occasionally. When I moved to get better light it turned and faced me + sat + sat + sat. Next 3 birds also flew up and sat in saplings.

Describe in detail the bird's relative size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern. Include details of bill, wing and tail shape. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions and illustrations is not enough. Describe only what you actually observe in the field:

This was a small sparrow with noticeably very small eyes. It was basically a very light-brown bird. The back was intricately scalloped with fine black and white markings and the back was distinctly darker than the face. There was a thin white central crown stripe. The face was pale with a pale grayish-brown eye patch. The eyebrow was pale white and definitely not buffy-orange as in adult plumage. (over)

Description (continued):

I did not notice chestnut streaks on the nape. Possibly I missed this; possibly first-year birds do not have chestnut streaks on the nape. When the bird turned toward me, I was surprised that it had absolutely no streaking on the breast. I would conclude that juvenile streaking on the breast is held only for a short time. The throat and belly were white but the sides of the upper breast were a rich buffy-orange. (This buffy-orange did not meet across the upper breast.)

Grasshopper Sparrows have flat squatty heads and a sizeable bill. This bird did not have a flat head and its bill was very small. Grasshopper Sparrows do not have intricately patterned backs. This bird did. Grasshopper Sparrows have a small white eye ring and often a yellow spot in front of the eye. This bird had no eye ring or yellow spot.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery, (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration):

~~There~~ There were many very faint chips from within the matted grass, but the bird never chipped from its perch on the sapling. The overall color of Grasshopper Sparrows does not change from face to back. This bird had a very light face but a ~~dark~~ much darker back. ~~The back of a Grasshopper~~

Describe the general and specific habitat in which you observed the bird:

Wet matted long-grass meadow with scattered cottonwood saplings. Closer to the small stream, the grass changed to cattails. The birds were only in the matted grass when I saw them. Mark Janos said they moved into the cattails when he chased them.

How did you eliminate similarly appearing species?

A Sharp-tailed Sparrow is basically a dark brown bird. This was a light-brown bird. Sharp-tail has a broad dark gray crown stripe. This bird had a narrow white central crown stripe. Sharp-tail has a relatively plain dark-brown back. This bird had an intricately scalloped back-pattern. Sharp-tail is ~~a~~ larger bird - medium-sized sparrow. This was a very small sparrow.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species?

I have observed Sharp-tailed Sparrows on their breeding ground in North Dakota.

I have observed Le Conte's Sparrows on their breeding grounds at McGregor Marsh south of Duluth, Minnesota. The McGregor marsh habitat is remarkably similar to that which is present at John Martin marsh in its low-water (drought) state.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: None. I was certain these were Le Conte's Sparrows.

b) after observation: National Geographic + Golden Guide Birds of North America

I spent 15 minutes discussing the description of these birds with Mark Janos after he saw them poorly in windy conditions. I spent 5 minutes talking to Bob Dickson. He and Jan Truan had never seen Le Conte's before and were not sure.

This report was written from reports made during _____, after observation _____ from memory X

Date and time report was written: December 3, 1990 8:30 PM

Reporting observer: Dan Bridger Signature: S. W. Dan Bridger

Address: 1925 S. Vaughn Way #207 Aurora, CO. 80014

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DENVER MUSEUM OF NATURAL HISTORY
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DENVER, CO 80205

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD ☐UNUSUAL RECORD ☒

Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.

Species: Le Conte's Sparrow / *Ammodramus leconteii*
(Vernacular Name) (Scientific Name)Date(s): December 4, 1990Number of birds seen: AT LEAST 6 Sex: Unknown Plumage: Subadult to AdultLatilong: 20 Distribution Code: — Habitat Code: MsLocality: SOUTH OF US 50.8 MI ON CR 14, EAST 1/2 MI. SECTION 34 T22S, R51W Elevation: 3860 FEETNearest town: FT. LYONS County: BENTTime(s) observed: 12:00 NOON TO 1:00 PMDuration of observation (e.g. 1 sec., 5 min., etc.): 10 SIGHTINGS TOTALING AT LEAST 5-6 MINUTES. LONGEST 2 MINUTES.

Other observers who saw the bird with you (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

None

Other observers who saw the bird independently (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

12/2 DAN BRIDGES 1925 S. Vaughn Way #207 Aurora 80014 12/3 MARK JANOS

Light conditions (position of bird to light and shade, direction and strength of light):

FULL SUN TO THE SOUTH OF ME BIRDS WERE SEEN TO THE EAST, NORTH AND NORTHWEST.
Optical equipment used (e.g. power, types): BAUSCH & LOMB ELITE 10X42Distance and how measured: 20-60 FEET PACEDIf photographed, type of equipment and film: NOISEWho else photographed the bird: —Describe the bird's behavior (e.g. flying, feeding, or habits used in identifying): WAS SEEN FEEDING IN BENT OVER CATTAIL STALKS ALONG EDGE OF WATERCOURSE.WHEN FLUSHED, IT WOULD FLY A SHORT DISTANCE AND DROP DOWN IN CATTAILS.

Describe in detail the bird's relative size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern. Include details of bill, wing and tail shape. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions and illustrations is not enough. Describe only what you actually observed in the field:

Comparable in size to a marsh wren which was a few feet from one of the birds. See attached description.

Description (continued): _____

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery, (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration):

GAVE ONE SHORT SONG SEGMENT - SHORT BUZZING NOTE - MATCH

IN RESPONSE TO A TAPE, TWO DIFFERENT BIRDS GAVE A

SERIES OF SHORT, SOFT CHIP NOTES. ONE OTHER BIRD INVESTIGATED.
BUT DID NOT CALL. DID NOT RESPOND TO SHARP-TAILED SONG, OR BIRD'S

Describe the general and specific habitat in which you observed the bird: SPARROW SONG.
SEEN WITHIN 20 FEET OF SMALL OPEN WATERCOURSE,

IN LARGE MOUNDS OF BENT OVER CATTAILS. ONE BIRD
WAS FLUSHED FROM SHORTER GRASS WITH SHALLOW WATER. AREA WITH
How did you eliminate similarly appearing species? SHALLOW WATER WAS BEGINNING TO FREEZE.

SEE ATTACHED.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species?

NONE w/ LE CONTE'S, SEEN SHARP-TAILED IN TEXAS,

GRASSHOPPER SPARROW SEVERAL TIMES IN COLORADO

List books, illustration, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) At time of observation: NONE

b) After observation: NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC 1ST EDITION, AUDUBON MASTER GUIDE VOL. 3

This report was written from reports made during X, after observation _____, from memory _____

Date and time report was written: 12/5/90

Reporting observer: NORMAN B. ERTAL

Signature: Norman B. Ertal

Address: 7761 EVERETT WAY, ARVADA, CO 80005

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HEAD

CENTRAL CROWN STRIPE - NARROW - PALE BUFF TO WHITE
LATERAL CROWN STRIPES - WIDER THAN CENTRAL, BROWNISH
BLACK. COARSE STREAKS TO NEARLY SOLID
ALL CROWN STRIPES ENDED ABRUPTLY TOGETHER
AT NAPE. BROAD BUFF SUPERCILIUM, GRAY AURICULARS,
DARK POSTERIOR EYE LINE CURVING SLIGHTLY ~~AND~~
DOWNWARD BEHIND AURICULARS BECOMING HEAVIER
FURTHER FROM EYE. DISTINCT WHITE EYE RING.
BUFF LORES AND MALAR AREA. SOME BIRDS HAD
FAINT DARK SUBMALAR STRIPE. SUPERCILIUM VARIED
FROM PALE BUFF TO BRIGHT ORANGE.

FINE STREAKS SEEN ON 2 BIRDS ~~ON~~ ^{BROWN} THE NAPE
THAT WERE PURPLISH IN COLOR, COLOR WAS DARK BROWN
IN OTHERS, ANGLE MAY NOT HAVE ALLOWED FOR
VISIBILITY OF COLOR. ONE BIRD HAD FINE STREAKS
BEHIND AURICULARS.

UNDERPARTS

BUFF COLORED BELLY. PALE BUFF TO WHITE
THROAT. BELLY - WHITE. UNDERTAIL COVERTS - BUFF
WITH ORANGISH TINT. FLANKS SAME COLOR WITH
DARK BROWN STREAKS. A COUPLE BIRDS HAD
VERY FINE STREAKS ON UPPER BREAST. SOME
BIRDS w/ STREAKS BEHIND AURICULARS.

TAIL - DARK BROWN. RUMP - NOT SEEN

BACK - BROWN WITH 4 TO 5 ROWS OF
DARK STREAKS GOING LENGTHWISE DOWN BACK

SCAPULARS

DARK BROWN CENTERS WITH PALE EDGES

WINGS - NO DISTINCT WING BARS. SLIGHTLY
- PALER EDGES TO ALL FEATHERS.

BARE PARTS

EYE - DARK

BILL - YELLOWISH BROWN TO PALE GRAY

LEGS - PINK

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Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.

Species: LE CONTE'S SPARROW | AMMODRAMUS LECONTEI
(Vernacular Name) (Scientific Name)Date(s): DECEMBER 8, 1990Number of birds seen: FIVE Sex: UNKNOWN Plumage: WINTERLocality: MARSH AT WEST END OF JOHN MARTIN RESERVOIR Elevation: 4000' (GUESS)Nearest town: LAS ANIMAS County: BENTTime(s) observed: 10 AM TO 11:30 AMDuration of observation (e.g. 1 sec., 5 min., etc.): TOTAL OF AT LEAST 30 MINUTES

Other observers who saw the bird with you (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

ROBERT ANDREWS, MARK JAMES, DUANE NELSON

Other observers who saw the bird independently (give names, addresses, telephone numbers)

DAN BRIDGES

Light conditions (position of bird to light and shade, direction and strength of light):

BRIGHT SUNLIGHT DIRECTLY ON BIRDSOptical equipment used (e.g. power, types): 10X BINOCULARS AND 30X TELESCOPEDistance, and how measured: 8-10 YARDS AT CLOSEST

If photographed, type of equipment and film: _____

Who else photographed the bird? _____

Describe the bird's behavior (e.g. flying, feeding, or habits used in identifying):

FORAGING IN MARSH, WHEN DISTURBED WOULD FREQUENTLY FLY A SHORT
DISTANCE AND LAND ON AN EXPOSED PERCH IN FULL SUNLIGHT AND VIEW.

Describe in detail the bird's relative size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern. Include details of bill, wing and tail shape. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions and illustrations is not enough. Describe only what you actually observe in the field:

I SAW A TOTAL OF FIVE DIFFERENT BIRDS - THERE COULD HAVE BEEN MORE IN THE
AREA - EASILY 6-10. ALL BIRDS I SAW LOOKED ESSENTIALLY THE SAME. THE BRIGHT
ORANGE EYE-LINES WERE THE MOST DISTINCTIVE FEATURE OF THE HEAD. THE
WHITE CENTRAL CROWN STRIPE AND GRAY EAR PATCH WERE ALSO VERY DISTINCTIVE.

Description (continued):

THE BUFFY FOREHEAD AND CHESTNUT WASH OR STREAKING ON THE NAPE WERE MORE DIFFICULT TO SEE, BUT WERE PRESENT ON ALL 5 BIRDS I SAW. THE UPPER BREAST WAS BRIGHT BUFFY AND UNSTREAKED - THE DISTINCT STREAKING WAS TOTALLY CONFINED TO THE FLANKS. THE BILL AND LEGS WERE LIGHT. THE UPPER BACK HAD DISTINCT BLACK STREAKS WITH QUITE A LOT OF WHITE (MOSTLY FEATHER BORDERS). THE TAIL WAS SHORT AND WHEN THE BIRDS FLEW THEIR FLIGHT LOOKED JUST LIKE THAT OF A GRASSHOPPER SPARROW - SAME SIZE AND FLIGHT PATTERN.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery, (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration):

BIRDS MADE OCCASIONAL CALLS. THEY SEEMED HIGHER PITCHED AND CLEARER THAN CALLS FROM THE SPIZELLA SPARROWS.

Describe the general and specific habitat in which you observed the bird:

MARSH WITH GRASSES, CATTAILS, VERY SMALL TREES.

How did you eliminate similarly appearing species?

SHARP-TAILED SPARROW BY WHITE CROWN STRIPE THAT WAS BUFFY ON FOREHEAD AND CHESTNUT WASH OR STREAKS ON NAPE (WELL SEEN). BIRD'S SPARROW BY UNSTREAKED BRIGHT BUFFY BREAST, WHITE CROWN STRIPE, CHESTNUT ON NAPE AND GRAY EAR PATCH.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species?

HAVE NEVER SEEN LECOMTE'S SPARROW BEFORE. HAVE SEEN SHARP-TAILED SPARROWS ON ONLY ONE OCCASION - NEVER SEEN BIRD'S SPARROW.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC FIELD GUIDE

b) after observation:

This report was written from reports made during _____, after observation _____ from memory X
Date and time report was written: 19 DECEMBER 1990 AT 9 pm

Reporting observer: PETER R. GENT Signature: Pete R. Gent

Address: 55 SOUTH 35th ST, BOULDER, CO 80303

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